STEADFAST MEN

Lesson 08 · The Empty Chair

Transcript · Wes Hart

Hey. Good to see you. Uh, glad you took a chair. Last time we talked about going first. Some of you did. Some of you went first to the snack table and called it leadership. I have led from a snack table. More than once. If you came in late, I'm Wes. You already know the voice. Glad you took a chair. Today is quieter than last time. I want to go slow. Uh, some of you are already bracing. You think I came to put your dad on trial. I didn't. I have loved a man and still needed a sentence he never spent. Both can be true. If you need to breathe, breathe. We'll tell the truth, and we'll be kind while we do it. Some of you can thank your father. Stay in the room. Some of you still brace when his name comes up. Stay. Uh, I am not ranking chairs from up here. I mean, if this was simple, most of us would have said it years ago. We didn't. So we say it here. We're gonna name a chair. Not the one under you. The one that raised you. You know, a boy reads a man long before he can explain him. Who sat at the end of the table. Who never did. Whether a voice in that house could actually be reached. You took in a lot of manhood while your feet still missed the floor. That is not a case against your dad. It is just where a man starts if he is gonna tell the truth. Uh, I have skipped this for years in rooms like this. I can talk— I can talk about courage all afternoon and stay foggy about the man who first showed me what a man was. Fog felt like loyalty. A lot of the time it was fear with a clean shirt on. So I'll set one line down. What sat in that chair was handed to you. What you do with the chair is yours.

One sentence holds four marks of a real man. I have not found a cleaner list. Here they are. A steadfast man stops waiting, picks up the weight, goes first, and works for God's pay, not the room's. You've heard that list in here, right? I'm gonna say it, and I am not gonna tour it. Today is the chair. The marks do not erase what you inherited. They tell a man he still has a life to live on the far side of that chair. Stay with the second line a second. Picks up the weight. Uh, hear what it does not mean. It does not— it does not mean the empty place was your fault. It does not mean God shrugs at what a boy had to live near. It means the day in front of you still has your name on it. A wound can explain a man for a long time and never once move him. I mean, I know that from the inside. I have gotten very clear about why I am the way I am, and then I have gone home and been that same man. Uh, clarity felt like progress. My wife could tell you it was just a better speech. You know, a man can sound healed and still be camped in the explanation. The explanation is comfortable. Nothing in the room has to change. Passivity sounds polite on this one. I stay off the subject. I call that respect. Uh, the chair does not stay off you just because you stayed off it. So here is the line, plain. What sat in the chair was handed to you. What you do with the chair is yours. If you remember one thing from this part, remember that understanding is not the same thing as owning. We'll tell the truth about what you were handed. We will not use it as a couch.

Paul names what belonged in a father's place. Ephesians six, verse four. This is the NIV. Fathers, do not exasperate your children. Instead, bring them up in the training and instruction of the Lord. Uh, stay with that. He does not ask for a perfect man. He asks— he asks for a father. A voice a boy can actually get to. Training. Instruction. The Lord in the room. Not only a paycheck. A paycheck can keep a roof up. It cannot raise a child. A boy can be fed and still be hungry for a man who will look at him. That hunger is not drama. Uh, it's the thing Paul just put in the chair. A voice you can get to. If that voice was thin in your house, or missing, you are not inventing a wound. You are telling the truth about a gap. My dad was not a storm. I need you to hear that. He came home. He kept things running. When I was scared of something ordinary, a tryout, a hard teacher, the first time I had to talk where people could see me, I would get— I would get one sentence out. He would hand me a plan. What time to leave. What to say first. What to do with my hands. Uh, the plan was love. I can see that now. It was also a shut door on the part of me that was scared. Uh, I learned a man handles fear by getting useful. Uh, I still do it. My wife will ask how I am, and I will brief her on the gutters. The gutters are fine. That was not the question. If your house had the plan and not the man you could reach, you are allowed to say so. I have watched a man defend his father so hard he couldn't tell the truth. Love can do that. Uh, love does not ask you to lie about the place he couldn't go. Gratitude and a gap can sit in the same sentence. Don't sand one of them off to save the other.

Now the chairs are not all the same. Do not sand yours until it matches mine. Uh, some never arrived. There was no name for the line where a father goes, and you learned to say, it's just us, so fast it sounded like a preference. Some, you know, left. He said he'd be back when the work eased, and it never eased, and nobody finished the story. Some died, and a plate still gets set. A coat stays on a hook because moving it would make the quiet louder. Some came home already gone. Body in the house. The rest of him loaned out until the house learned not to knock. Some were a storm. You learned the rooms by his volume. Uh, some of you made yourselves hard to notice. Some of you stepped in front of it so a smaller kid wouldn't have to. And some of you had a good man there. I mean, I am glad. He showed up. He paid what needed paying. There is still a place he could not reach. You are not ungrateful for noticing. Every man here inherited something. You may have to look harder for yours. Looking harder is not betrayal. I still carry mine into my own house. Uh, I come in from the day, and I stop in the doorway before I walk into a full table. My daughter caught it. She said, you always stop. She wasn't scolding. She was, you know, reporting. I told her I left something in the truck. I hadn't. The old chair walks in with me. For a second I don't want it on my face. Stopping is human. Living in the doorway is a choice. How many of you have a true sentence about your father you have never said out loud? Take your time. All right. You are not strange for having it. You won't shout it at this whole room. You will say it at a table. You are not the only one carrying a chair.

A boy will not leave a hole that size empty. Somebody, or something, ends up in it. And whatever ends up there helps raise him. Uh, sometimes the boy climbs in himself. He writes a

private manual. Never ask twice. Never look like you need a ride. Never let them see you stuck. Uh, some real strength comes out of that. So does a man nobody can father anymore. Not a brother. Not the Lord. An honest question starts to feel like a test. I have a note in my phone called things I don't need. The note needs its own drawer. That note is the manual. Still open. Still hiring. For a lot of boys a hard rule takes the seat. Need somebody, and you will pay for it. So he grows up, you know, wanting nothing. He tells his people he's simple. He believes it. They can live beside him for years and still not know what he'd love. Uh, other boys become the family news. Who is upset. Who needs smoothing. Who must not— who must not be bothered. Ask him how he is, and he briefs you on everybody else. His own insides don't get a vote. Or, I mean, a crowd takes the seat. He keeps a list of men who think he's solid. He says yes to the crew, the setup, the job nobody wanted, because a nod feels like a father. The years stack up. He is still collecting nods. And sometimes the seat holds the man he swore he'd never be. He promises he will never go quiet the way his father went quiet. Uh, so he talks. Advice. Commentary. He fills every quiet in the house so nobody will feel left. His kids cannot find a man who listens. The promise was love. It also became his whole picture. Name what took your seat. The manual. The shrug. The news report. The nod. The promise. You can thank what kept you alive and still tell it the seat is closed.

Let me tell you about a man I sat with a long time. I'll call him, uh, Dean. If a couch had to move, Dean was already there. Guys trusted him. I did too. At his house, one chair at the table had a job. It held the mail. Not for a messy night. For years. His wife set supper at the counter. The boy did homework on the rug, because the table was Dad's papers. Dean would say— Dean would say he'd clear it when life eased up. Life did not ease up. He was home. He called it providing. The chair at the end stayed hired. One evening the boy asked if they could eat at the table like his buddy's family. Dean said the table was how a man stays ahead. The boy said okay. He did not ask again. Later the boy started taking his plate down the hall. Door mostly shut. Dean got hot. He called it disrespect. He told us with his jaw tight. I asked him who taught that boy a shut door was a normal supper. Dean went still. He looked at his hands. He said he needed to go home. A few days later he moved the mail. No speech. Into a crate on the floor. He wiped the chair and sat down. His knee bumped the table, because his body wasn't used to that seat. He called down the hall. The boy looked at the chair like it might be a trick. Dean said, sit down. I'm here. They ate soup. The boy talked about a kickball fight. Dean felt a speech coming. He swallowed it. He said, then what happened. The boy kept going. Dean told me the soup went lukewarm. First meal in that chair he could remember on purpose. He had been home every night. His son still had a blank chair. He had filled it with paper and called the paper love. The habit explained him. It did not excuse the next supper. What he did with the chair, once he saw it, was his. His boy was not asking for a philosophy. He was asking if that chair could hold a father. Dean did not fix his childhood that day. He sat down. That was the owning.

Now listen. This is where a man slips. The chair explains you. It does not excuse you. Nobody handed a boy a vote on whether his father would stay, or soften, or ever look up. Uh, it happened. It shaped you. God knows the lines of it. He is not bored by your story. From here, what you do with it is yours. The people near you do not live in the house you grew up in. They live with the man who walks in now. If you go sharp, you know, they meet the sharp. If you go gone, they meet the gone. They did not sign up for a house they never lived in. The sharp tone can be shaped like his silence and still be yours today. I mean, she meets the voice in the room now. Not the old house. Owning it is not blaming the boy you were. Owning it is refusing to make them pay for that house now. I have used— I have used a clear story like it was a changed life. Uh, you sound wise. The room stays the same. My boy asked me once what my dad was like. I said, he was a good man, we're good, so fast I almost pulled something. He wasn't asking for a verdict. He was asking if the subject was allowed in our house. I closed it. I called the speed respect. It was fear. Uh, I have also tried to set the whole chair in my wife's lap. One night I walked her through my childhood like she had agreed to finish it. She was, uh, kind. She was not my father. She was not the Lord. When she couldn't make me feel done, I went quiet. I called it, she doesn't get it. What she got was a chair she was never meant to hold. She can know the story. She should not have to be the chair. You can father with a hole. You don't get to hand her the hole and call it honesty.

So what does a man do with this. Two things. I'm gonna stop at two. There is more mercy ahead than we are opening here. Today is not the day we patch the hole and call the feeling finished. Today we tell the truth about the chair. First, he says it. Uh, out loud. Where his own ears can hear it. Not a— not a documentary. One sentence. He was gone before I had words for it. He ate at our table, and I still don't know what he thought of me. I learned the house by whether it was safe to breathe. He was good to us, and I am still waiting on one sentence. If yours starts with, we don't really go there, that sentence already went there. Second, he lets it weigh what it weighs. Men will, you know, trade almost anything to skip this. Uh, we get insightful. We find a clean line and feel grown because it didn't cost us anything. Grief is not a hobby you pick up. Grief is telling the truth about the size of what never came. A voice you needed. A man who would stay in the question. Words you waited on as a boy and, uh, still catch yourself listening for. Let it be as heavy as it actually was. A tidy line will not carry that weight. If you skip the weight, you will keep leaking it on people who did not dig the hole. I sat down once to write my father a letter I was not going to send. I mean, I cheated early. I made headings. What he did well. A little box I called growth areas, like he was up for a promotion. My dad is not on my staff. A pile of thanks. Not one line about what I needed. Thanks can be true and still be a place to hide. Uh, I went back. I wrote the plain line. Shorter. It cost more.

An older man sat with us a long time. I'll call him Warren. His father died before they ever talked straight. Uh, Warren had made the visits. Rain. The garden. Whether the old truck had another year. He kept— he kept meaning to say the real thing next time. Next time was a funeral. He

stood in a line of people who said his dad was a good man. Warren nodded. He told me later he wanted to say, good is not the same as known. He didn't say it in that line. Uh, he told me he felt foolish, writing to a man who couldn't read it. Uh, he wrote the page anyway. What he needed. What never came. One thing he was honestly glad of. Nowhere to send it. He kept it. Then he brought one sentence to the group. His voice, you know, shook. He didn't decorate it. A younger guy started with, at least. Warren lifted a hand. He said, don't. Not mean. Just finished being smoothed. I mean, I backed him. Another man said, I'm sorry. Then nobody hurried. Warren said the sentence got lighter once a second man heard it without trying to bury it. He folded the page into a book he actually opens. Not a shrine. A place his hands already go. He didn't need a reply from the grave. He needed the sentence said where another man stayed put. If you are older, hear me. A door can close before the talk does. Death can get there first. Distance can. You can still say what needed saying. Uh, write it. Read one sentence to a brother. The words need a chair to land in, even if your father cannot hear them. And if a man starts curing you, you can say, not yet. He can hear you. He cannot sit in that chair for you.

Let me walk the room, because one picture will not fit all of you. Uh, young men. Stop waiting for a ghost to sit down before you become a man. Tell the truth about the chair and still grow up. An empty seat is not a pass to stay a boy. Uh, if you're single, hear this clean. A future wife cannot sit in that chair. She can love you. She cannot be your father. Don't hand her a job she was never given. And don't park your life until some seat fills. You already have a life. Live it as a man who tells the truth. Husbands. You can— you can father with a hole in you. You must not dump that chair in her lap. Your kids are not a project you use to finish your own childhood. They are not a stage for the old weather either. If the days are split between houses, your kids are reading the chair you sit in on the day that is yours. Not the speech about the schedule. Uh, show up in the ordinary hours. That is a man taking the chair he has now. If he is alive and still hard to reach, don't wait on his growing up before you start yours. If the chair was, you know, cruel, cruel is not the same as empty. Both are real. You don't owe us a soft version. You also don't have to build a monster before you're allowed to speak. Kind. Slow. Name what was. And if you think this hour is only for a sadder man, look again. A good chair can still leave a gap. You are in this too. If the work is going well, don't let the hours fool you. Hours will not father you. They will not father your kids if all they get is the last ten minutes. A full calendar is just another way to be gone inside your own house. I have, uh, hidden in being useful. Useful gets praised. Useful can still miss a boy in the hall.

Let me bring this home. The chair at the end of the table taught you more than you asked to learn. It explains you. It does not excuse you. What sat in the chair was handed to you. What you do with the chair is yours. What I hope— what I hope you carry is not a finished healing. I hope you leave having named the chair in plain words, and knowing the naming counts. You are not stuck as the boy in the story. You are a man who can tell the truth about what happened and still decide the next thing. That is dignity. It is not a shove. The marks still stand. I won't tour

them. A steadfast man stops waiting, picks up the weight, goes first, and works for God's pay, not the room's. Your workbook is where this gets particular. Uh, in a minute you sit at the tables and work this part together. Get the questions in your ear. Finish this out loud. The chair at the end of my table was blank. If blank is not, you know, your word, put the true word there. Then, what one thing did that chair teach you? And can you say one true sentence about your father, without a speech? Write your— write your father a letter you will not send. Tell him what you needed, what you did not get, and what you're grateful for, if anything. Uh, keep it where you can find it. You'll want it later. I mean, tell a brother the sentence. Not the letter, unless you want to. Let him say, me too, or, I'm sorry. Don't hurry past either one. If he starts a cure, stop him. Uh, he can hear you. He cannot sit there for you. Carry this. What sat in the chair was handed to you. What you do with the chair is yours. Tables are yours. Work that part of the workbook together. I'll be around.